

Japan Daily Brief

Sunday, September 13, 2026

1,696 words · 7 min read

RE: Okinawa gov race underway · DPRK missiles post-Freedom Edge · BOJ rate hike imminent · Chubu Electric fraud · China visa hikes

NIKKEI 225
64,011.34
▼ -3.60%

USD/JPY
153.55
▼ -1.69%

BRENT
\$104.61
▲ +6.83%

BOJ RATE
1.25%

• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 Okinawa voters cast ballots today in a gubernatorial election pitting incumbent Denny Tamaki, seeking a third term on an anti-base platform, against an LDP-backed challenger who would hand the ruling coalition its first Okinawa governorship in 12 years.
- 2 North Korea fired multiple short-range ballistic missiles toward the Sea of Japan on September 12, one day after Freedom Edge 2026 US-Japan-South Korea trilateral exercises concluded, with the US stating the launches posed no immediate threat and beginning consultations with allies.
- 3 The Bank of Japan is set to raise its policy rate to 1.25% at its Thursday-Friday monetary policy meeting, with multiple outlets reporting the decision as a near-certainty.

• TOP STORIES

POLITICS-DIET

Okinawa gubernatorial election voting underway — LDP bids to end 12-year absence from governorship

Voting is in progress in Okinawa's gubernatorial election, with incumbent Governor **Denny Tamaki** running for a third term and an LDP-backed challenger seeking the seat for the first time since 2014; the US military base relocation to Henoko and the island's economy are the central issues. Turnout reached 25.56% as of 6 p.m. local time, above the comparable pace of the prior election, per Asahi Shimbun.

per Mainichi: "Voting underway in Okinawa governor race with US base, economy in focus"

MAINICHI

DPRK

North Korea fires multiple short-range ballistic missiles into Sea of Japan after Freedom Edge drills conclude

South Korea's Joint Chiefs of Staff confirmed North Korea fired multiple short-range ballistic missiles toward the Sea of Japan on September 12, one day after the US-Japan-South Korea Freedom Edge 2026 trilateral

exercises concluded near Jeju Island; the US stated the launches did not pose an immediate threat and began consultations with allies. North Korean state media remained silent on the launches, consistent with its recent pattern of not publicly acknowledging missile tests.

AL JAZEERA · ABC NEWS · KOREA JOONGANG DAILY · NIPPON.COM · MAINICHI

• OVERNIGHT

DIPLOMACY

Japan has few cards to play one month after Putin's Northern Territories visit · The Japan Times

One month after President Putin visited the disputed Northern Territories, Japan Times analysis finds Tokyo constrained in its response by dependence on Russian oil and gas as conflict continues in the Middle East. Japan has protested the Khabarovsk war-monument controversy and Equal Earth map dispute but cannot impose deeper sanctions without fuel-supply risk.

ALLIANCE

Canada seeks deeper GCAP cooperation with Japan in radar, satellite, mission control · The Japan Times

Canada's ambassador to Japan said Ottawa can contribute to the Global Combat Air Programme in aircraft systems, mission control, radar and satellite technology. The statement signals Canadian interest in joining the Japan-UK-Italy trilateral GCAP framework as a partner contributor.

ENERGY

Chubu Electric president and chairman to resign over Hamaoka nuclear data fraud · The Japan Times

Chubu Electric Power's president and chairman are set to resign following allegations of falsified earthquake-risk data submitted to Japan's nuclear regulator during safety reviews of the Hamaoka nuclear plant, per NHK. The departures mark a major governance failure at a plant that has been offline since 2011.

TRADE/ECONOMY

Japan's future US investments to concentrate on power sector, trade minister says · Nikkei Asia

METI Minister Ryosei Akazawa told Nikkei Asia that Japan's future investments in the United States under the strategic framework will focus on the power sector. The statement provides the first sectoral guidance on where the \$550 billion US-Japan strategic investment pledge will be directed.

KOREA-JAPAN

Sado mine memorial held without South Korea attendance for third straight year · Mainichi

South Korea skipped the memorial ceremony at the Sado Island gold and silver mine for a third consecutive year, where laborers including those from the Korean Peninsula worked during WWII. The absence continues to strain Japan-South Korea historical reconciliation efforts.

• STAT OF THE DAY

7x

China's visa-fee hike for Japanese nationals, citing reciprocity

China raised visa fees sevenfold for Japanese visitors, its Foreign Ministry citing Japan's July introduction of higher fees for foreign nationals as the reciprocity basis, extending Beijing's multi-instrument economic-pressure campaign.

China hikes visa fee sevenfold for Japanese visitors, citing 'reciprocity' — Nikkei Asia

PM Watch: No confirmed PM appearance today · 4 day(s) since last confirmed appearance

CHINA

China confirmed a sevenfold visa-fee hike for Japanese nationals, citing Japan's July fee increase for foreign nationals as the reciprocity basis — the latest in an accelerating sequence of economic-pressure measures that has also included September's anti-dumping levies on Japanese dichlorosilane. No new Senkaku CCG intrusion or JASDF scramble appears in today's articles.

NORTH KOREA

North Korea fired multiple short-range ballistic missiles toward the Sea of Japan on September 12, one day after Freedom Edge 2026 US-Japan-South Korea trilateral exercises concluded near Jeju Island; South Korea's Joint Chiefs confirmed the launches and the US stated they posed no immediate threat while beginning allied consultations. North Korean state media remained silent on the launches.

RUSSIA

Japan Times analysis published today finds Tokyo constrained in its response to Putin's Northern Territories visit one month ago, as dependence on Russian oil and natural gas — with Brent above \$104/barrel — limits the sanctions options available to the Takaichi government.

Senkaku / ECS: No new Senkaku CCG intrusion or JASDF scramble in today's articles; the sustained CCG patrol baseline from prior weeks continues as the standing posture.

Bottom line: North Korea's September 12 SRBM salvo — fired immediately after Freedom Edge 2026 concluded — is the day's sharpest adversarial signal, continuing the pattern of DPRK missile responses to trilateral exercises; watch for Japan's formal MOFA protest and whether the BOJ rate hike Thursday compounds yen-market pressure amid elevated regional tension.

• OP-EDS, COMMENTARIES & EVENTS

OP-EDS & THINK TANK COMMENTARY

SASAKAWA PEACE FOUNDATION

Ocean Impact Navigator for Japan From Blue Impact Finance Momentum to Action — Visualizing Business Opportunities and Impact in the Blue Economy —

The report maps Japan's ocean-economy investment landscape to identify actionable business opportunities in the blue economy through an impact finance framework.

The Sasakawa Peace Foundation's Ocean Impact Navigator charts Japan's blue economy from a finance-momentum-to-action perspective, visualizing where impact capital can flow within Japan's maritime and ocean sectors. The framework is designed for institutional investors and policymakers seeking measurable ocean-sustainability outcomes. Given Japan's maritime geography and dependence on ocean resources, the mapping has potential utility for economic-security and supply-chain resilience analysis.

• PUBLIC SENTIMENT & APPROVAL POLLING

POLLSTER	APPROVE	DISAPPROVE
JNN · Sep 7, 2026	62.5%	34.9%
Nikkei · Sep 5, 2026	62%	32%
Asahi · Sep 5, 2026	53%	33%
ANN · Sep 5, 2026	55.4%	29.9%
Kyodo · Sep 10, 2026	50.2%	33.9%
Yomiuri · Sep 5, 2026	56%	32%
FNN · Sep 5, 2026	62.5%	32%
NHK · Sep 10, 2026	52.8%	33.2%

Discourse: The Nikkei poll showing a rebound to 62% approval diverges sharply from the Kyodo (50.2%) and Mainichi (41%) surveys, with the Kyodo result reflecting sustained fiscal anxiety following the income tax cut; the September 16 cabinet reshuffle and today's Okinawa election result are the next political inflection points.

Poll tracker: [Observing Japan approval-rating aggregator](#) →

• UPCOMING

Sep
13

Okinawa gubernatorial election results expected tonight

Votes are being counted today; the outcome directly affects the Henoko relocation standoff and the Takaichi government's US alliance management, with the LDP seeking to end 12 years out of the governorship.

Sep
16

Takaichi cabinet reshuffle

Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi is confirmed to execute a cabinet reshuffle on September 16, with reporting indicating a focus on US-savvy ministers and possible portfolio changes including the LDP Diet Affairs chair appointment.

Sep
18

Bank of Japan Monetary Policy Meeting (Day 1)

The BOJ's two-day policy meeting convenes Thursday-Friday; multiple outlets report a rate hike to 1.25% is widely expected, which would be a continuation of the normalization cycle.

Sep
22

PM Takaichi addresses UN General Assembly

Prime Minister Takaichi is confirmed to address the UN General Assembly on September 22, per prior reporting; her speech is expected to address Japan's regional security environment and international order themes.

Oct
1

GCAP trilateral program milestones — Canada seeking entry (estimate)

Canada's ambassador to Japan has publicly expressed interest in GCAP cooperation in aircraft, mission control, radar and satellite technologies; program governance milestones for the Japan-UK-Italy next-generation fighter are an ongoing watch item.

• JAPANESE GOVERNMENT

KANTEI · CABINET · MOFA · MOD · METI · MOF · BOJ · SUNDAY, SEPTEMBER 13, 2026

自衛隊 · SELF-DEFENSE FORCES

SDF prepares overseas forest-fire response in Indonesia — first-ever international firefighting deployment

Jiji Press reports the SDF is preparing firefighting activities in Indonesia in response to forest fires, marking the first time Japan's Self-Defense Forces have conducted such operations outside Japan.

→ Jiji Press ↗

DIET SESSIONS / LDP

LDP

Former Deputy Chief Cabinet Secretary Hideki Murai being considered for LDP Diet Affairs Committee chair

Asahi Shimbun reports the LDP is adjusting to appoint former Deputy Chief Cabinet Secretary Hideki Murai as its Diet Affairs Committee chair, a key role managing floor strategy in the House of Representatives ahead of the September 16 cabinet reshuffle.

OKINAWA PREFECTURE

Gubernatorial election voting underway — Tamaki vs. LDP-backed challenger, LDP seeking first win in 12 years

Voting began September 13 in Okinawa's gubernatorial election, with incumbent Governor Denny Tamaki running for a third term on opposition to the Henoko US base relocation; the LDP-backed challenger seeks to reclaim the seat for the first time in 12 years, with turnout at 25.56% as of 6 p.m. per Asahi Shimbun.

• BUSINESS & ECONOMY

FINANCE · NIKKEI ASIA · HULIC

Japan developer Hulic and partners commit \$1.5 billion to Tokyo office tower deal

Hulic and partner developers have committed \$1.5 billion to a Tokyo office tower transaction, one of the largest recent commercial property deals in the capital amid rising construction costs and strong institutional demand for premium office space.

• INDO-PACIFIC

DPRK · AL JAZEERA / MULTIPLE

North Korea fires multiple SRBMs into Sea of Japan hours after Freedom Edge 2026 concludes

South Korea's Joint Chiefs confirmed multiple short-range ballistic missile launches toward the Sea of Japan on September 12, timed immediately after the conclusion of US-Japan-South Korea Freedom Edge 2026 exercises; the US said launches posed no immediate threat and began allied consultations.

INDO-PACIFIC · NEW INDIAN EXPRESS

As Xi visits India for BRICS, India's military engages all three Quad partners including Japan

India's military is simultaneously engaging all three Quad partners — the US, Japan, and Australia — as Chinese President Xi Jinping arrives in India for the BRICS summit, a juxtaposition with direct implications for Japan's Quad coalition management.

INDO-PACIFIC · NIKKEI ASIA

Japan's Nidec exits Cambodia production amid Thailand-Cambodia border conflict

Nidec is withdrawing from Cambodia manufacturing operations due to the Thailand-Cambodia border conflict, illustrating how Southeast Asian regional instability is disrupting Japanese corporate supply chains.

• THE WIRE

POLITICS-DIET • NIKKEI ASIA

Liechtenstein, close to Japan's imperial family, grants women a path to rule

Nikkei Asia interviews Liechtenstein's leadership on its decision to allow women to ascend to rule, framed in context of the country's close ties to Japan's imperial family and Japan's own ongoing debate over female succession to the Chrysanthemum Throne.

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